

SDEV2801 - The Art of Facilitation

Private Chat
Yes / No

I gave you a homework last class. Did you do it?

Private Chat

What do you need to submit this Friday?

Yes / No

I sent you an email yesterday. Did you read it?

What stood out for you in that email?

Communication

We generally communicate with our:

1. Face
2. Eyes
3. Body
4. Voice
5. Pen

How effective do you consider yourself as a communicator overall? (0-100)

1. Face (open, expressive, or aloof, icy, stoic)
2. Eyes (maintain or avoid)
3. Body (at ease with others, or awkward)
4. Voice (tone, style, comfort, volume)
5. Pen (writing skills, expressing, articulating)

True or False (in chat)

People who communicate well are more likely to be respected and recognized in the workplace

Yes/No (in chat)

Could a person who generally does not talk much be a good communicator?

Yes/No (in chat)

Can shy, highly introverted people become good communicators?

How?

Desire

Motivation

Practice

Small improvements

Results

Mastery

What is Group Facilitation?

The process of guiding a group of people through a structured conversation or meeting to help them achieve a common goal.

Yes / No

Is it possible that your great skills might one day land you in a leadership position?

0-100%

If so, as a leader, what are the chances of you facilitating meetings with your team?

The Art of Facilitation

Have a you ever attended a great meeting?

School, friends, hobbies, communicate, work?

Text one important skill of a good facilitator.

Facilitation Skills

Must be a good communicator

No need to be an entertainer (though it could help)

Plan

Introduce

Listen

Observe

Interject, connect, bridge

Focus on goals

Let’s say you are facilitating a group of total strangers on a very important topic that affects everyone. You notice one person is not saying anything. What would you do?

1. Let them be. They may be shy, or have nothing to add
2. Avoid eye contact with that person not to pressure them
3. Surprise them by calling them by name and asking them a question

Facilitation Skills



Role of a facilitator

1. NOT to present!!!
2. Design and plan the process
3. Number of participants
4. Nature of participation needed
5. How well participants know the subject
6. Allotted time
7. Design a realistic agenda
8. Design the group process
9. Open discussion
10. Listen, connect, summarize

A facilitator must be a sponge



Main job of a facilitator

Get to the outcome of the meeting

- It is a mental effort
- It takes practice
- Needs a plan (agenda)
- Decide when to move on to the next item

Warning!

Keep a neutral stance



Role of a facilitator

1. Guide and control the meeting
2. Ensure effective participation
3. Ensure agenda is followed
4. Engage participants
5. Connect comments if needed
6. Manage derailing comments
7. Summarize the meeting outcomes

Skills Needed to Facilitate

1. Interest in exploring
2. Interest in interpersonal connections
3. Organizational skills
4. Knowledge of the subject
5. Interest in solving problems (analytical skills)
6. But most importantly…
7. Emotional intelligence
    1. Being aware of your own emotions
    2. Being able to control your own emotions
    3. Being aware of someone else's emotions
    4. Being able to control someone else's emotions

Facilitation Ground Rules

- One person speaks at a time
- AVOID circles (makes the conversation mechanical)
- Raise your physical hand to contribute
- Listen to what others are saying (do NOT repeat…add)
- No mocking or attacking other people's ideas
- Respect each other

Facilitation

To Do	To Avoid
manage the meeting	take part in the discussion
give participants the relevant structure and tools	try to influence the outcome
make sure everyone is heard	offer own view
help participants identify their goals	make decisions
help participants to develop their action plans	take control of the comments
provide leadership	
help others assume responsibility and take charge	

Great Questions…a Vital Role of a Facilitator

Questions are supremely important in facilitation.

Some questions are trivial/boring; some inspire participation

Let's Try

Which is the best question at a meeting if a company is facing a market share crisis?

1. Which department is causing this crisis?
2. What do you think we should change?
3. We are losing market share. What can we do to increase our sales volume?

Great Questions

Let’s say it is 13 years ago, and I am the Chair of SDEV

I have come to your class to get your honest feedback about your classes, your teachers, resources, NAIT, and your overall experience.

What is a good first question I should ask the class?

Your Facilitation Process

1. Submit 3 interesting topics (40 words each: what, why) and 3 solid questions for each topic
2. #1 should be the one you most want to do; #3 the least.
3. Together, we will choose one for you (private chat in class)
4. Research your topic to learn more about it
5. Write 8 solid questions for your session
6. Submit your 60-second intro exactly + all 8 questions (in class)
7. I will divide the class into groups of 5-7
8. On the day of your turn, log into Teams. Everyone else is free
9. One by one, you will hold your session (10 minutes each in total)
10. You will introduce your topic (60 seconds)
11. Then start with your first question

Finding Yourself in a Pickle in a Meeting



1. Do NOT allow autopilot rotation
2. Briefly connect ideas if possible
3. Ho-hum or irrelevant questions are deadly
4. Unclear questions will force the facilitator to repeat or present/explain
5. Questions requiring expertise…dead end…mere speculation

Let's Practice –Topic Choice
All answers in "public" chat

I will display some of the past topics. My own rating: Useless (0), OK (5), Good (8), Great (10).

Give me the topic # then your rating of 0-10, 0 meaning you do not have interest or knowledge to discuss this, 10 meaning this topic is relevant to you, your life, career and future.

Example: #1 6

Let’s Practice

#1

Requiring people 70 years old and above to have an annual physical check before renewing driving licence?

Let’s Practice

#2

Choosing a Toyota over a BMW??

Let’s Practice

#3

Allowing doctor-directed euthanasia vs prolonged suffering

Let’s Practice

#4

Given technologies such as AI, governments implementing universal basic income (UBI)?

Let’s Practice

#5

A 4-day week instead of a 5-day week?

Let’s Practice

#6

Canada becoming the 51st US state

Let’s Practice

#7

The Role of Technology in Classrooms: A Tool or a Distraction?

Let’s Practice

#8

Your views on NAIT as a school?

Let’s Practice

#9

Mental health literacy as a required component of post-secondary education

Let’s Practice

#10

When cultural differences become obstacles in a society?

Let’s Practice

#11

Solo work vs collaboration with others in college

Let’s Practice

#12

The impact of rising interest rates

Let’s Practice

#13

The impact of US applying 50% tariff on Canadian goods

Now Let's Practice Great Questions
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: The government implementing universal basic income (UBI) where everyone receive a certain amount to live on

#1

Do you know what UBI is?

Let’s Practice – The Question
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: The government implementing universal basic income (UBI) where everyone receive a certain amount to live on

#2

Do you think AI will replace jobs?

Let’s Practice – The Question
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: The government implementing universal basic income (UBI) where everyone receive a certain amount to live on

#3

Can governments afford UBI?

Let’s Practice – The Question
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: Mental health literacy as a required component of post-secondary education

#1

Do you know someone who suffers from mental illness?

Let’s Practice – The Question
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: Mental health literacy as a required component of post-secondary education

#2

What could colleges do to help students who struggle with mental illness?

Let’s Practice – The Question
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: Mental health literacy as a required component of post-secondary education

#3

Can support in a college help overcome mental illness?

Let’s Practice – The Question
Rate the question 0-10

Topic: Mental health literacy as a required component of post-secondary education

#4

Does mental illness affect one’s academic performance?

Recap for your facilitation session

1. Do NOT allow autopilot rounds of answers
2. You need to briefly connect from one person to another
3. Ho-hum topics are fundamentally a waste of time
4. Badly-worded Qs can create awkward moments
5. Unclear questions can result in facilitator becoming a presenter
6. Irrelevant Qs (to participants) can be deadly….silence
7. Qs requiring expertise…dead end…mere speculation

Facilitation Drills

Text me (privately) a any topic and a suitable question for it



Facilitation Drills & Review

Text me your topic, 60-sec intro & 8 “great, engaging, clear” Qs



Next Class (due at the start of the class)

Come with a Word document. Drop off in Chat.

- One Word document
- Describe each topic in 40 words or more and why you wish to discuss it with your peers
- Include 3 opening questions you would ask in your session

Before and during facilitation

Once you know your group, do NOT discuss helping each other!

Every comment must be connected to the next comment

Bonus marks: Positive body language, voice, style, listening, connecting and confidence in your topic

Deductions: Asking a question that needs to be repeated

Getting into autopilot mode

Not addressing silence

Becoming a presenter

Allowing anyone to take over, or stay disengaged

What to do with eager participates?

Facilitation Drill

Everyone: please raise your hand in Teams, then turn on your webcam & audio

Subject: AI taking over teaching

Background: Harvard has created a course entirely taught by an avatar of one if its best professors. A chatbot is answering student questions. Grading is done by AI, but reviewed by a grad student. The entire course costs $700 and it has been sold as a package to many other universities already. This can revolutionize teaching and learning. We want to discuss what you, as a NAIT student, think about this idea.

Q1: Would you be willing to be taught by top-notch avatar teachers, learning the exact same concepts, yet reducing your tuition by more than ½?

Facilitation Question Drills

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth rate in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10 (public), 0 totally unsuitable, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

1 Facilitator question: What would entice young people to want kids?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

2 Facilitator question: What is the real reason young people do not want marriage, family or children given that the birth rate in many parts of the word is plummeting?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

4 Facilitator question: Should birth control measures be illegal to improve childbirth?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

5 Facilitator question: What impact does a declining birth rate have on the economy?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

6 Facilitator question: What are the ethical considerations around government incentives to increase birth rates?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

7 Facilitator question: Is social media, isolation, mental health related to young people’s view of or hope for future?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

8 Facilitator question: Isn’t it just selfish to choose not to have children?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

9 Facilitator question: If birth rates keep dropping, won't society just collapse?

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

10 Facilitator question: What's going on with population trends?

Last One

Drill:

Topic: Plummeting childbirth in many parts of the world

Rate 0-10, 0 totally useless, unclear, irrelevant, 10, great, engaging

11 Facilitator question: How will population decline affect us?

Facilitation Plan

- I have randomly put you in groups
- Due to class size, it will take 2 weeks
- When it is not your turn, you are free. Don’t log in.
- This is process for each session:
  - First intro.
  - Ask your first question at the start of minute 4
  - Bridge each comment
  - Mange the session (who is quiet, give turn to everyone, etc…)
  - Stop at minute 15
  - Spend one minute summarizing what you heard

Facilitation Day

- Video on during this class. Focus on the session.
- Everyone, when your peer starts, start your timer also. This way you know how much time he/she has left (to limit your last comments accordingly)
- If you wish to comment, just raise your physical hand (not Teams)
- If you have already offered many comments, allow others to contribute
- You DO NOT need to comment on every question. But participate with meaningful comments.
- Only comment when you have something NEW to add
- Finally, this is learning. Do not try to rescue if the facilitator is not clear or the questions are hard to understand. Ask, probe the facilitator.

Facilitation Question Practice

- *Government restriction of freedom of speech.*
- *Animals used for scientific and/or commercial testing.*
- *Video game violence and its impact on youth.*
- *Human cloning*
- *Should AI tools be allowed in post-secondary courses?*
- *Media censorship – when is it acceptable?*
- *Subcontracting jobs to developing countries*
- *Assessment deadlines - flexible in post-secondary programs?*
- *Social media - more harmful or beneficial overall?*